CAMBRIDGE
International Education

Cambridge O Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/11**

Paper 1 Reading **May/June 2025**

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 50

Published

This mark scheme is published as an aid to teachers and candidates, to indicate the requirements of the examination. It shows the basis on which Examiners were instructed to award marks. It does not indicate the details of the discussions that took place at an Examiners' meeting before marking began, which would have considered the acceptability of alternative answers.

Mark schemes should be read in conjunction with the question paper and the Principal Examiner Report for Teachers.

Cambridge International will not enter into discussions about these mark schemes.

Cambridge International is publishing the mark schemes for the May/June 2025 series for most Cambridge IGCSE, Cambridge International A and AS Level components, and some Cambridge O Level components.

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PUBLISHED

Generic Marking Principles

These general marking principles must be applied by all examiners when marking candidate answers. They should be applied alongside the specific content of the mark scheme or generic level descriptions for a question. Each question paper and mark scheme will also comply with these marking principles.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 1:

Marks must be awarded in line with:

- the specific content of the mark scheme or the generic level descriptors for the question
- the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the generic level descriptors for the question
- the standard of response required by a candidate as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 2:

Marks awarded are always **whole marks** (not half marks, or other fractions).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 3:

Marks must be awarded **positively**:

- marks are awarded for correct/valid answers, as defined in the mark scheme. However, credit is given for valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme, referring to your Team Leader as appropriate
- marks are awarded when candidates clearly demonstrate what they know and can do
- marks are not deducted for errors
- marks are not deducted for omissions
- answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 4:

Rules must be applied consistently, e.g. in situations where candidates have not followed instructions or in the application of generic level descriptors.

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GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 5: Marks should be awarded using the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme for the question (however; the use of the full mark range may be limited according to the quality of the candidate responses seen).
GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 6: Marks awarded are based solely on the requirements as defined in the mark scheme. Marks should not be awarded with grade thresholds or grade descriptors in mind.

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English & Media subject specific general marking principles
(To be read in conjunction with the Generic Marking Principles (and requiring further guidance on how to place marks within levels))

Components using level descriptors:

- We use level descriptors as a guide to broad understanding of the qualities normally expected of, or typical of, work in a level.
- Level descriptors are a means of general guidance and should not be interpreted as hurdle statements.
- Where indicative content notes are supplied for a question, these are *not* a prescription of required content, and must not be treated as such. Alternative correct points and unexpected answers in candidates' scripts must be given marks that fairly reflect the knowledge and skills demonstrated.
- While we may have legitimate expectations as to the ground most answers may occupy, we must at all times be prepared to meet candidates on their chosen ground, provided it is relevant ground (e.g. clearly related to and derived from a relevant passage/text and meeting the mark scheme requirements for the question).

Components using point-based marking:

Point marking is often used to reward knowledge, understanding and application of skills. We give credit where the candidate's answer shows relevant knowledge, understanding and application of skills in answering the question. We do not give credit where the answer shows confusion.

From this it follows that we:

a DO credit answers which are worded differently from the mark scheme if they clearly convey the same meaning (unless the mark scheme requires a specific term).
b DO credit alternative answers/examples which are not written in the mark scheme if they are correct.
c DO credit answers where candidates give more than one correct answer in one prompt/numbered/scaffolded space where extended writing is required rather than list-type answers. For example, questions that require *n* reasons (e.g. State two reasons…).
d DO NOT credit answers simply for using a 'key term' unless that is all that is required. (Check for evidence it is understood and not used incorrectly.)
e DO NOT credit answers which are obviously self-contradicting or trying to cover all possibilities.
f DO NOT give further credit for what is effectively repetition of a correct point already credited unless the language itself is being tested. This applies equally to 'mirror statements' (i.e. polluted/not polluted).
g DO NOT require spellings to be correct, unless this is part of the test. However, spellings of syllabus terms must allow for clear and unambiguous separation from other syllabus terms with which they may be confused (e.g. Corrasion/Corrosion).

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Annotations guidance for centres

Examiners use a system of annotations as a shorthand for communicating their marking decisions to one another. Examiners are trained during the standardisation process on how and when to use annotations. The purpose of annotations is to inform the standard isation and monitoring processes and guide the supervising examiners when they are checking the work of examiners within their team. The meaning of annotations and how they are used is specific to each component and is understood by all examiners who mark the component.

We publish annotations in our mark schemes to help centres understand the annotations they may see on copies of scripts. Note that there may not be a direct correlation between the number of annotations on a script and the mark awarded. Similarly, the use of an annotation may not be an indication of the quality of the response.

The annotations listed below were available to examiners marking this component in this series.

Annotations

Annotation	Meaning
	Correct answer
	Relevant supporting detail
	Relevant Development of an idea or detail
	Relevant content point made (**Q3(a)** Summary)
	Candidate's own vocabulary and structures appropriately used (**Q3(a)** Summary)

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Question 1

This question tests the following reading assessment objectives (16 marks)

R1 demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings
R2 demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes

Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(a)	**From paragraph 1, give <u>one</u> reason why Hassan's grandmother decided to sell snacks from outside the train station.** • it was busy // (there would be) lots of people / customers / crush / crowd (in the rush hour) • she wanted (it) to be a commercial success / make money	**1**	
1(b)	**Identify the <u>two</u> most successful items sold from the food stalls.** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • 'bhelpuri' // paper cones of puffed rice (with chutney, vegetables and herbs, spices) • milky tea	**2**	
1(c)	**<u>Using your own words</u>, explain what the text means by 'Greatly encouraged'. (line 6)** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • very / much / a lot / really / well / strongly / highly • motivated / inspired / confident / felt positive about / given hope	**2**	

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(d)	**From paragraph 2, give <u>two</u> things that Grandmother did to increase the number of customers after 'the snack bicycles became a commercial success.' (lines 4-5)** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • erected / established / opened a restaurant • employed Bappu / a cook • added dishes / added spicy prawns // included southern / traditional / new / more dishes // expanded menu	**2**	
1(e)	**Explain what Hassan is feeling when he remembers that 'The kitchen used to be the heart and soul of the old family business – always so full of life back then, filled with constant comings and goings.' (lines 17-18)** • fondness // happy (memories) / pleasure // warm (feelings) // (a sense) of time passing // misses it // nostalgia	**1**	*LOOK FOR a <u>feeling</u>, not an explanation of what life was like.*

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(f)	**In paragraph 5, how did Hassan feel about being in the shanty town outside the family compound?** **Give <u>two</u> details from the text to support your answer.** **Feeling** Reward any sense of **nervousness** or **insecurity** however expressed, such as: • nervous / wary / unsure / overwhelmed / vulnerable / disturbed / unsafe / uncomfortable / dislike ACCEPT: *scared / threatened / it was dangerous* **Details** Details must come from separate bullets. Award 1 mark for each detail up to a maximum of 2 marks: • 'out of the (immediate) safety (of our family compound)' • 'sea of roof scraps' // roof tops stretch into distance (size) • '<u>notorious</u> (shanty) town' // a place where bad things happen • 'hazy air' (of pollution) • 'roar of roosters' // loud noise of roosters (2)	3	✓ Correct feeling DET Supporting detail *The supporting details can be quoted or paraphrased. A paraphrase must clearly convey the original meaning.* *Do not accept line / paragraph references (only) or ellipses for textual details.*
1(g)(i)	**Hassan's father noticed a change in the types of people living in the area. What was the change?** • (people were) affluent / millionaires / rich(er) // professional / skilled / businesspeople (living there) // successful people	1	

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(g)(ii)	**What did Hassan's father decide to do in response to the change?** • transform / change completely / update / upgrade / renovate the restaurant // increase size / seating capacity of the restaurant // made the restaurant more fancy / flashy	1	

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>1(h)</td><td>
Explain <u>using your own words</u> Hassan's different feelings and opinions about his mother.

Give <u>three</u> details from anywhere in the text to support your answer.
<table>
<tr><th>Hassan feels / thinks ✓</th><th>Supporting textual detail DET</th></tr>
<tr><td>1 she has influenced / inspired him / she is a role model / she is a good teacher</td><td>'I cannot give her enough credit for what became of me' / 'I grew up watching her' work / involves him in preparing the food: 'stirring of the cauldron' / 'remarkable talent' / 'no dish finer than her pearl spot' / his 'benchmark'</td></tr>
<tr><td>2 impressed / admiration / proud</td><td>'remarkable talent' / 'no dish finer than her pearl spot' / '(capacity of) professional chefs / multitask'/ his 'benchmark'</td></tr>
<tr><td>3 she is skilful / talented / efficient / professional / good cook / she works hard</td><td>'remarkable talent' / 'no dish finer than her pearl spot' / 'robust yet refined' / '(capacity of) professional chefs / multitask' / 'her tiny figure darting barefoot' / 'chopping, dipping, frying' / 'I would find mother working'</td></tr>
</table>
</td><td>3</td><td>
<table>
<tr><td>✓</td><td>Each correct feeling / opinion</td></tr>
<tr><td>DET</td><td>Supporting detail</td></tr>
</table>

For a supporting textual detail do NOT accept
• line or paragraph references (only)
• ellipses to substitute words
</td></tr>
</table>

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(h)	**Hassan feels / thinks** ✓ / **Supporting textual detail** DET **4 love / close / a bond / affection / feels joy in her company** / ‘I grew up watching her’ / ‘we’d chat about my day at school’ / involves him in preparing the food: ‘stirring of the cauldron’ / renames dish ‘Hassan’s Dry Chicken’ after her son **5 felt heard by his mother / grateful / appreciated her / she encourages him / she gives him opportunities / she had confidence in him** / ‘I cannot give her enough credit for what became of me’ / ‘at mother’s suggestion’ goes to the market with Bappu / ‘Let him speak’ / he is allowed to sit at ‘the back of the restaurant’ for the serious meeting with Bappu **6 she is calm(ing) / sensible / cool / peacemaker / made things go smoothly** / ‘always ready to calm Father down’ / ‘common sense’ / ‘sitting coolly’ / ‘the much-needed brake’ / **7 she is key to the success / she is in charge / she works hard / she is wise / logical** / ‘our restaurant quickly established itself’ / ‘working on the accounts’ / ‘dispatching Bappu to the market’ / ‘Let him speak’ / ‘renamed by Mother ‘Hassan’s Dry Chicken’ / ‘her tiny figure darting barefoot’/ ‘chopping, dipping, frying’ / ‘I would find mother working’		

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(h)	*The **supporting textual detail** can be quoted or paraphrased. A paraphrase must clearly convey the original meaning,* • *e.g. he thought she was calm because she slowed father down when needed = feeling 6 + DET ('she slowed father down when needed' = acceptable paraphrase of 'much needed brake')*	**3**	

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Question 2

This question tests reading assessment objective (9 marks)

R4 demonstrate understanding of how writers achieve effects and influence readers.

Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
2(a)	**Read this extract from the text:** **'In went an over-size stone fountain. Over the centre of the dining room, Father hung a huge glitter-ball made of mirrors, which revolved over a tiny dance floor.' (lines 30–32)** **What does the writer want to suggest to us about the changes to the restaurant?** • (the fountain / glitter-ball / changes) were showy / fancy / inappropriate / ridiculous / <u>too</u> big / <u>too</u> many / extreme / drastic / excessive / extravagant / have spoilt the restaurant // (the restaurant has) lost its cosy feel	1	*LOOK FOR a comment / judgement on the changes*
2(b)	**Explain why the writer uses the word 'smothering' rather than the word 'covering' in the expression 'before smothering them with multitudes of signed photographs of film stars'. (line 33)** • <u>absolutely</u> / <u>totally</u> filled / covered // no space between them // overcrowded • to exaggerate the amount // to show an excessive / extreme number (of photos) // <u>too</u> many (photos)	1	*LOOK FOR any suggestion of unrestrained covering / over the top / (far) too many* *ACCEPT: <u>almost</u> completely covered*

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
2(c)	**Read this sentence from the text:** **'Fruiterers delicately built pomegranate towers, a bed of purple tissue fanning out below them in the shape of lotus flowers; baskets filled with coconuts and mangoes rose vertically, creating sweet-smelling sculptures of expensive fruit hand-polished to a waxy gloss.' (lines 44–46)** **What <u>two</u> impressions does the writer want to convey to the reader in this sentence?** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • abundance / lots / variety (of fruit) • artistic / elaborate shapes / skill / care taken / attention to detail / designed / fancy • fragrance / perfume / scent / aroma // nice smell • exotic / sophisticated / elegant / decadent / costly / luxurious • beautiful / wonderful / amazing / impressive / inviting / <u>look</u> delicious • shiny / gleaming	**2**	

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance

2(d)	**Read this sentence from the text:**
	
	'Bappu sat opposite them in a stiff-backed chair, like in a court of law, nervously stroking his moustache.' (lines 48–49)
	
	What effect does the writer suggest about the situation by using the phrase 'like in a court of law'?
	
	Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks:
	
	• it is serious / formal / important
	• it is a worrying / uncomfortable / (in)tense (situation) // Bappu is worried / uncomfortable / anxious / vulnerable / powerless
	• Bappu / he is being judged / blamed / accused // he is on trial // as if he has committed a crime // as if they are discussing a case
	• something important will be decided // it could have consequences (for Bappu) // Bappu / he could be punished / reprimanded
		2	

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr>
<td>2(e)</td>
<td>
Identify <u>one example</u> from the text below of how the writer uses language effectively to convey his opinion of the chicken dish (1)

‘The offending item stood between them – a copper bowl of chicken masala. Drawn by its fiery fumes, I reached over, dipping my fingers into the rich rustic sauce and sucked them greedily. The gloopy masala trickled slowly down my throat, a heavy, oily paste of red chilli.
“Only three orders last week. We fix it now or I drop it from the menu,” Father yelled. He spooned a slop of the sauce onto a plate. “Could be better. You agree?”’ (lines 52–56)

Explain the impression the writer creates in the example you have identified. (2)

Responses must select from any of the following relevant examples <u>in part</u>, <u>whole</u> or <u>combined</u>:

<table>
<tr><th>Example ✓ 1 mark</th><th>Explanation ✓ up to 2 marks</th></tr>
<tr><td>1 ‘the offending item’</td><td>the less popular dish, people do not like it // causing upset, anger, harm // not good enough // Bappu, the dish has committed a crime // like evidence, an exhibit in court // exaggeration</td></tr>
<tr><td>2 ‘drawn by its fiery fumes’</td><td>is (first) attracted by it, tempting // strong smell // spicy, heat, incredibly hot // is overpowering // a sense of danger, risk</td></tr>
</table>
</td>
<td>3</td>
<td>
Example: Do NOT accept line references (only). If ellipses are included, only accept the words which are given. If sense is lost, do not award the mark.

Example: ACCEPT a single word if rich enough to create an effect,
e.g. fiery, slop
but NOT words which only carry literal meaning,
e.g. item, throat

Explanation: LOOK FOR understanding of the connotations / impact / effect of particular word(s) / image / technique <u>in the identified example</u>.

Explanation: These ideas are suggestions. Candidates may offer other creditworthy ideas.
</td>
</tr>
</table>

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>2(e)</td><td>
<table>
<tr><th>Example ✓</th><th>Explanation ✓</th></tr>
<tr><td>3 ‘rich rustic sauce’</td><td>strong flavour // thick // unsophisticated // (looks) tasty, appetising, delicious</td></tr>
<tr><td>4 ‘sucked them greedily’</td><td>enthusiasm, eats with pleasure, eats without wanting to stop // expecting something nice // eats noisily // tasty</td></tr>
<tr><td>5 ‘gloopy masala trickled slowly down my throat’</td><td>less pleasant // consistency is thick, sticky // hard to swallow // dislikes // not as nice as it looked, smelled (in bowl)</td></tr>
<tr><td>6 ‘heavy, oily paste of red chilli’</td><td>not pleasant, awful to eat, dislikes // horrible texture // greasy // overpowering // unhealthy // spicy</td></tr>
<tr><td>7 ‘spooned a slop of the sauce’</td><td>unappetising, unattractive // wet, liquid // unsophisticated // looks horrible, a mess // disgust, disapproval</td></tr>
</table>
</td><td></td><td></td></tr>
</table>

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Question 3(a)

This question tests the following reading assessment objectives (10 marks)

R1 demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings
R5 select and use information for specific purposes

and the following writing assessment objectives (10 marks)

W2 organise and structure ideas and opinions for deliberate effect
W3 use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures appropriate to context

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
3(a)	**Summarise the benefits and attractions of different kinds of swimming pools, according to Text B.** **You must use continuous writing (not note form).** **Use your own words as far as possible.** **Avoid copying long sections of the text.** **Your summary should be no more than 150 words.** **Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 10 marks for the quality of your writing.** Use the Marking Criteria for **Question 3** (Table **R**, **Reading** and Table **W**, **Writing**). **INDICATIVE READING CONTENT** Candidates may refer to any of the points below: 1 learn to swim / have lessons // learn lifesaving / essential skill 2 swim / have fun with friends // socialise // share (pool) 3 reasonably priced / cheap (exercise) // free swim (neighbour's pool) 4 workout / fitness / exercise / health benefits 5 holiday / tourist accommodation / hotel (with pool) 6 relaxing 7 private / home pool is a luxury / indulgence / status symbol / opportunity to show off 8 indoor pools mean you can swim all year / all the time 9 an eco-pool can be sustainable / chemical-free / low-tech // a sustainable pool can be chemical-free / low-tech / eco-friendly 10 eco-pools can be cheaper to run // natural purification can be cheaper 11 eco-pools / natural purification enrich the pool with oxygen / support beneficial bacteria / support eco-system / provide habitat / are good for aquatic life / wildlife 12 natural cleaning agents / alternatives to chemical cleaners reduce water consumption / the need to clean / (re-)fill frequently	**20**	*ACCEPT: environmentally friendly for eco or sustainable*

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Marking criteria for Question 3(a)

Table R, Reading

Use the following table to give a mark out of 10 for reading.

Level	Marks	Description
5	**9–10**	• A wide range of relevant ideas (R1) • Ideas are skilfully selected and used (R5)
4	**7–8**	• A good range of relevant ideas (R1) • Ideas are carefully selected and used (R5)
3	**5–6**	• A range of relevant ideas (R1) • Relevant ideas selected; may include excess material (R5)
2	**3–4**	• Some relevant ideas used; may include indiscriminate selection (R1 and R5)
1	**1–2**	• Some ideas referred to; limited evidence of selection (R1and R5)
0	**0**	• No creditable content

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Table W, Writing

Use the following table to give a mark out of 10 for writing.

Level	Marks	Description
5	**9–10**	**A relevant response that is expressed clearly, fluently and mostly with concision** • The response is well organised (W2) • The response is the candidate's own words and/or structures where appropriate with a range of vocabulary which clarifies meaning (W3)
4	**7–8**	**A relevant response that is expressed clearly with some areas of concision** • The response is organised (W2) • The response is the candidate's own words and/or structures where appropriate (W3)
3	**5–6**	**A relevant response that is generally expressed clearly** • There is some evidence of organisation (W2) • The response is mainly the candidate's own words and/or structures where appropriate (W3)
2	**3–4**	**A relevant response that can generally be followed** • There are areas of the response expressed in the candidate's own words and/or structures (W2 and W3)
1	**1–2**	**The response lacks clarity** • There may be long explanations or the response may be brief (W2) • There is occasional use of own words and/or structures (W3)
0	**0**	• No creditable content.

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Question 3(b)

This question tests the following reading assessment objective (5 marks)

R2 demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>3(b)</td><td>
<u>Imagine you are Ted, the neighbour who refused the offer to use Mario's swimming pool.</u>

Mario is surprised and wants to understand your reasons. Mario asks you a question.

Give your answer to Mario's question, using information from the text.

<u>Mario's question</u>: I think that sharing my swimming pool is an environmentally friendly thing to do.

What is your opinion and why?
Relevant perspective: Ted does not think Mario's offer to share his swimming pool is an environmentally friendly thing to do. Accept a very broad interpretation of 'environmentally friendly' e.g. cleanliness of water.

INDICATIVE CONTENT
Responses might use any of the following ideas / details:

<table>
<tr><th>Supporting details from the text ✓</th><th>Developments DEV</th></tr>
<tr><td>1 global water scarcity / droughts // a precious resource // has to clean / empty and re-fill pool frequently

2 a luxury / indulgence / status symbol</td><td>• private pool uses massive amount of water / selfish when world faces drought / waste of water / could save water by using natural alternatives
• an opportunity to show off rather than help the environment / chose an expensive (conventional) pool / irresponsible spending</td></tr>
</table>
</td><td>5</td><td>
<table>
<tr><td>✓</td><td>An idea or a detail from the text supporting a valid perspective</td></tr>
<tr><td>DEV</td><td>Development of a point / an idea</td></tr>
</table>

For DEVELOPMENT, look for expansion of a point or detail, or an idea not explicit in the text but a valid inference

DEVELOPMENTS are examples; candidates may offer other creditworthy suggestions
</td></tr>
</table>

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
3(b)	**Supporting details from the text ✓** / **Developments DEV** **3 pool uses chemicals / chlorine // chemicals / chlorine cause dry skin / green hair // there are alternative cleaning agents / filtering systems** **4 man-made pool is bad / not sustainable // (Ted) cares too much about the environment** **5 heat so much / a lot of water // not solar heated** • bad for health / wildlife / cause pollution // ignored the alternative natural cleaning methods // Mario should have done more research // needs careful monitoring or water is unclean / dangerous • a private pool is unnecessary // wild swimming / swimming in natural environment is preferable • - does not use green energy / could have opted for solar heating / wastes energy		

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Table R, Reading

Use the following table to give a mark out of 5 for reading.

Level	Marks	Description
3	**4–5**	• Consistent and relevant perspective offered • Ideas are supported and developed
2	**2–3**	• Generally relevant perspective offered • Some attempt to support or develop
1	**1**	• Some awareness of opinion or attitude
0	**0**	• No creditable content

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